Chapter 8: Fight Past Gems Dark. Expect Wounds.

York looked down at the teams from Aschelle and Terrian on the arena field and announced, “This fight is to gems dark except for Rhys, who has permission to fight past his going dark.”

Rhys looked over at the Aschellean team. They were smiling victoriously. He knew what that meant – They intended to kill him. Aschelle tended to have accidents when taking down war mages shielding, and often struck after they knew it was down. In this fight, they wouldn’t have to make it look like an accident.

“We have your back,” Hrod assured him.

Rhys suddenly looked over, noticing Hrod.

York called for the battle to begin. Aiden, Quex, and Freya all charged at Rhys. Fortunately, Flynn attacked Freya to pull her off of him and Hrod attacked Quex.

Rhys fought against Aiden, which was a very even match. Both fought with swords. Rhys’s flamed. Aiden’s

sparked.

Strike after strike came and their shielding held. Shielding protected them from cuts, wounds, and death, but not from all the pain. Rhys felt every strike.

Rhys took a strike from Aiden and shook uncontrollably for a moment, but blasted with fire from his sword to push Aiden back. He looked down at the gem on his bracer. It was fading. His shielding was going down.

Flynn was the first to have his shield go dark, and Lorelay had hers go down shortly after.

When a war mage's shielding went down, he was supposed to be given a free walk off the field and touch no one, but Lorelay subtly stabbed Rhys as she went by.

His shielding held, but it was one more strike against it. Why did Aschelle always have to cheat, and how did they get away with it? He didn't have time to think about it, as he was in the middle of a fight.

Honestly, he wouldn't have cared if they lost, as they hadn't stolen the items, so nothing would change, but York made it a battle for his life.

He turned, noticing that Sean was walking off the field and Freya was running toward him. He blasted fire at her and turned to parry a strike from Aiden, but missed that Quex was throwing his war hammer.

That was an odd tactic, as war mages didn't generally let go of their weapons unless they were intended to be

thrown, as they didn't want an enemy war mage picking it up. Obviously, Aschelle was trying to go for the kill.

The war hammer hit hard, and Rhys's gem went dark. He'd been told he could fight past his gem going dark. That had never been done before. Should he? If he stayed and fought, he'd die, but if they lost, he'd be turned over to Aschelle who would kill him, and it was two against three. If he left, Hrod couldn't fight all three. He had to keep fighting.

He blasted fire at Quex, who was running to pick up his hammer, and struck at Freya.

Hrod attacked Quex to get him away from Rhys, but both Aiden and Freya were attacking him.

As Rhys blocked a strike from Aiden's sword, Freya whipped her blades on chains and struck across his back. Rhys could feel the blood flow, but he had to keep fighting. His life depended on it.

It didn't help that he heard people from Ramere chanting, "We want blood!" How could they cheer for him bleeding?

He had to tune it out or he'd miss more parries. Fortunately, Hrod hit Freya hard enough to knock her to the ground and have her shield go dark.

Hrod also stepped between her and Rhys, so she couldn't take the cheap shot on her way off the field.

The Aschelleans cheered for her as she left, but Hrod focused on the fight. It was him and Rhys against Aiden

and Quex. All of them had low gems, and Rhys was bleeding.

Hrod jumped in to fight Aiden. He and Quex were the better match to fight, but Rhys didn't need to be taking any more shocking blasts, and Hrod still had some shielding to absorb them.

The shocks drained his shielding quickly, but he made some great hits against Aiden. As he fought, he saw Rhys fall to the ground in a pool of blood. Quex was poised to make the killing blow and smash Rhys's head in, but Hrod jumped in front of him, striking Quex as he did.

Hrod took a hard blow, and his shielding went down, but he'd taken Quex's down too. They were both out.

If only he could stay and fight, but he couldn't. Rhys was allowed to fight past his gem going dark. He wasn't.

He made sure Quex left without getting a blow on Rhys, and then he walked off the field.

That left only Aiden and Rhys. Aiden's gem was glowing faintly, but Rhys was lying on the ground unable to get up.

Aiden sent shocks from his sword, and Rhys screamed in pain.

As Aiden walked over to strike the killing blow and put his sword through Rhys's chest, Rhys put all the energy he could into his sword and blasted Aiden with a huge fireball. Then Rhys collapsed.

Aiden's shielding went down and the fire burned his

skin. He fell to the ground, rolling around, trying to put it out.

“Terrian wins!” York announced as both teams ran to the field to help their wounded teammate.

Catria was quickly beside Rhys. She put her hands on him and let the healing energy from her flow through him. She hadn’t learned to control her new powers as well as she’d like, but it wasn’t hard for her to heal him. As she healed, a white light shone around her and Rhys.

Everyone was astonished when Rhys sat up. Healing him so he wouldn’t die was something healers could do, but healing him that well was unusual.

Everyone gasped as Rhys stood up. He was weak and needed help to walk, but him just standing was amazing.

After Catria did what she could for Rhys, she went over to where Aiden was lying. “I’m willing to help,” she informed team Aschelle. She then walked over and put her hand on Aiden.

“What kind of trick is this?” Quex called out to her, but she raised her hand to him to indicate that he needed to be quiet, and she healed Aiden. The white glow coming from her as she did. Soon, the burns were gone and Aiden was up. Everyone stared at her.

She turned around and noticed that both Hrod and Sean were beside her with their hands on their weapons in case they needed to fight.

“You are unicorn,” Freya hissed. “I thought the report

a lie.”

Team Aschelle stared at her, and Aiden was the only one to say, “Thank you,” to her. Everyone else looked at her as if they’d just seen a pixie riding a tiger. No, that would be more possible to them.

“Let’s go,” Hrod urged. He took her arm and walked her back to their team, with Sean following behind her, watching their backs.

“You’ve really drawn attention to yourself,” Hrod noted. “Let’s all get back to our platform.”

“I’m sorry,” Catria apologized, “but I had to help.”

“You are unicorn,” Hrod replied. “But you also may have just put a target on your back.”

Catria grabbed his arm. “Do you really think I will be in trouble because I healed their captain?”

Hrod patted her arm. “Not because you healed him, but how you did. I’m sure they are glad Aiden is healed, but other war mage teams are now terrified of you. You definitely have enemies now.”